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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55599772.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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The day Glimmer and Bow were paired for a fandom event

by Bagge

Summary

When a fandom event assigns Glimmer's favourite artist to illustrate her fic, she is faced with an impossible task: She has to talk to him.

Notes

Written as a leadup to the 2024 spop big bang event, as a shameless thank you to the organiser, who happens to like glimbow.

"Shit! Fuck! Balls!" a cute, pink haired woman dressed in pastel colours yelled to no one in particular.

"What the fuck is your fucking problem, Glimmer?" her room mate, dressed in worn jeans, a faded band t-shirt and a scruffy cat ear head band answered from her usual place, perched like a - yes - cat in a worn down armchair.

"The organisers for that big fandom event just announced the pairings of writers and artist, Catra," Glimmer answered from her usual place in the equally worn sofa, so littered with blankets, throw pillows, stuffed toys, candy wrappers and various pieces of home electronics that it looked more like a scruffy birds nest than anything else.

Catra lit up and started to thumb a cracked phone. "They finally announced it? Good. Can't wait to see what weirdo I'm paired up with."

"That's just it!" Glimmer claimed, accusingly waving with her pink tablet. "Now I'm supposed to make contact with some random weirdo."

"Yeah? So what?"

"So what if it is a *weirdo*?"

"Of course it's a weirdo. Everyone in fandom is a weirdo. Since when is that a problem."

"I have to contact them!" Glimmer huffed.

Catra grinned at her. "Are you *shy*?"

"SHUT UP, I'M NOT SHY!"

Catra deftly caught the throw pillow Glimmer threw at her and tossed it back. "Poor little princess, forced to interact with a smelly artist."

"You don't know they will be smelly," Glimmer objected.

"Of course I do, all artists are smelly."

"You are an artist, Catra."

"Yeah, so I know what I'm talking about."

Glimmer took a deep breath and clicked her tablet. "OK, here goes... OH SHIT!"

"Good 'oh shit' or bad 'oh shit?"

Glimmer stared at the tablet, face white. "I got CupidsArrows for an artist!"

Catra frowned. "They are not all that bad. Way too cutsy art style for my taste but it should work well with your schmaltz."

"I write angst, Catra," Glimmer said between gritted teeth. "My stories have depth."

"They end in kisses, don't they?" Catra countered. "Anyway, what's the problem? Don't think CupidsArrows can do your tortured characters justice?"

"No, absolutely not," Glimmer gasped. "They are amazing, a fandom legend. And I... I have to TALK to them."

Catra gave her a toothy grin, but was distracted from a teasing comment by a notification from her phone.

"Huh, seems like my writer contacted me already. Oh God, What kind of user name is HorseGuuuurl?"

"Someone who like horses?" Glimmer suggested.

"Yeah, no kidding," Catra said, a smirk spreading over her lips as her eyes darted back and forth over the phone, "They sent me a synopsis. This reads like Xena Warrior Princess meets Black Beauty."

Glimmer chewed her lips thoughtfully. "Sounds pretty badass, actually."

"Of course it's badass. Just because it's dumb doesn't mean it isn't badass."

"So, you can work with that?"

Catra cracked her knuckles. "I'll show that horse dork the most badass horse she's ever seen." She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "And you will contact your weeb and tell them they better make your master piece justice."

"I don't need any pep talk, Catra," Glimmer protested, despite her cheeks heating up slightly.

"Atta girl! Now write them."

Glimmer took a deep breath, and then another one.

"OK, Ok. I can do that..." With trembling fingers she pressed down on her tablet a few times. The she tossed it away with a groan. "This is haaaaaaaaard."

"Poor princess," Catra teased.

"Why don't we just work together you and me?" Glimmer moaned. "Then I won't have to talk to strangers."

Catra's expression suddenly became a bit guarded.

"We... don't really work together anymore, Glimmer. In case you forgotten the... Collaboration."

Glimmer nodded slowly. "Oh yeah. The Collaboration."

They looked at each other in silence for a few moments, then both of them shuddered.

"For the record, I'm still sorry about how that turned out," Glimmer mumbled.

"Yeah, I think we both learned valuable lessons that day," Catra agreed.

"Not to work together, for one," Glimmer said. She picked up the tablet again. "I'll contact the artist now."

Catra relaxed again. "Atta girl!"

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Hi!

"They might not be awake now anyw... THEY'RE ANSWERING!"

CupidsArrows: Hi! Nice to meet you.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: HI! Nice to meet you too!

CupidsArrows: :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: We're paired together.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: For the event, I mean.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: The fandom event.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Like, you draw and I write.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: In collaboration.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: For the event.

CupidsArrows: I just saw I was paired with you and I'm really glad for it. I'm such a fan of your writing.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You... are?

CupidsArrows: Of course! Your roleswap au is my all time favorite.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It... is?

CupidsArrows: To tell the truth I was a bit hesitant to put you at the top of my priority list.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You... were?

CupidsArrows: Haha... I guess I am a bit shy to work with someone as talented as you...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: YOU ARE TALENTED! YOUR ART IS REALLY GOOD! I'M HAPPY TO WORK WITH YOU.

CupidsArrows: Awww, you're making me blush :-)

CupidsArrows: How is the writing going?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: The writing?

CupidsArrows: For the event?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: ...

CupidsArrows: I read your synopsis. It's really good.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT? IT'S TRASH! I'VE REWRITTEN IT FIVE TIMES!

CupidsArrows: Oh! Well, I really liked it. Such a good premise. I can't wait to read the new synopsis.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: The... new...

CupidsArrows: Like, if you rewrote it? Can I see the new one?

"CATRA! THEY WANTS TO SEE MY SYNOPSIS"

"So? Send them your synopsis."

"But it's traaaaaaaaaash."

"It's not trash."

"OF COURSE IT'S TRASH! EVERYTHING I WRITE IS TRASH!"

Catra looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"Hey, no trashtalking my best friend." In one fluent motion she had left the armchair and hovered over Glimmer, her body language threatening. "Say after me."

"I don't need..."

"SAY AFTER ME!"

Glimmer swallowed and nodded, eyes wide.

"I, Glimmer Moon."

"Do I really have to..."

"*I, Glimmer Moon*."

"I, Glimmer Moon."

"Am a fucking princess."

"Am a fucking princess."

"I'm talented as fuck."

"I'm talented as fuck."

"And if anyone doesn't see that, they are a fucking hack who doesn't deserve the time of my day, and if they ever insult me, Catra will find a way to push their heads inside their own asshole over the internet. Got all that?"

"Um, not quite..."

"Doesn't matter, you got the spirit of the thing. Now send your artist chump your synopsis and tell them to grovel at your feet for the chance of working with you."

Catra held her gaze for a moment, and then moved back to her armchair. Slightly flustered, Glimmer returned to her tablet.

"Thanks for the pep talk, but it might be juuuuust a tad extreme."

"Not at all, Catra smirked. A shrinking violet like you needs help to be assertive. I'm happy to assist."

Glimmer stuck out her tongue at her, but dutifully copied her synopsis, cleared a spelling mistake and pasted it into the chat.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's not finished yet, but hopefully it gives some idea of what I'm going for.

CupidsArrows: Wow! This is awesome. The story will be SO GREAT.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Do you really think so?

CupidsArrows: Absolutely. You are giving me so many ideas for the drawing.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's amazing! I really look forward to see what you will do with it.

CupidsArrows: I don't think I can do your story justice, but I'll certainly try :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm sure whatever you do it will be very good.

CupidsArrows: Thank you so much. If you believe in me, then I can do it :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I believe in you!

CupidsArrows: How goes the rest of the writing? Can I read the story?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: NOT YET! NOT FINNISHED! GOTTA GO! BYE!

CupidsArrows: Oh!
CupidsArrows: OK.
CupidsArrows: Talk to you later.

Glimmer tossed her tablet to the floor, where it thankfully landed on a pile of dirty laundry that cushioned the fall. "CATRA!"

"Yeah?"

"THEY WANT TO READ MY STORY!"

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Yeah, that's kinda the whole deal with the event."

Glimmer gave her a panicy look. "But then I have to show it to them!"

Catra crossed her arms. "Yes?"

"But... I'm not ready to show it."

"Don't you already have, like, twenty chapters of that thing?"

"But it's a mess."

"So what?"

"But... what if they don't like it?"

Catra sighed. "Do we need to have the pep talk again?"

"No, I'll... I'll just clean it up, and then I'll send it to them." Glimmer reached behind the sofa and pulled up a pink laptop.

"Didn't you have a lab report coming up?"

Glimmer gave her an aghast look. "Who can think of school when the rightful heir to the throne is in danger?"

"Atta girl," Catra happily said as Glimmer started to write. She picked up her stylus.

For a few minutes silence reigned in the small apartment (a rare enough occurrence) as both women focused on their work. Glimmer's expression was hard as her fingers danced over the

keyboard in description of the protagonist's righteous anger at her strife. She frowned at a sudden thought. "Hey, we're almost out of groceries. What are we eating tonight?"

"There's some instant noodles left," Catra said, not looking up from her drawing tablet.

Glimmer nodded contently and went back to put her beloved character in situations.

- - -

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Hi!

CupidsArrows: Hi! Nice to talk to you again.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Nice to talk to you too :-)

CupidsArrows: How has your day been?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Great!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Well, OK.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I sat up all night writing.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I slpet through the alarm
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: *slept
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I came late to my class
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then my professor yelled at me
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I yelled at my professor
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I went to the library to read the textbook instead of staying to be insulted ath the lecture.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I wrote fanfic instead of reading the subject
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I was tired, so I decided I needed a treat
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I cut off my professor on the way to the cafeteria to get before him in line
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then my professor yelled at me
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I yelled at my professor

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I had blueberry muffins iwth extra sparkles and a caramel latte with whipped cream
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And then I returned to the library
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: ANd then I finished chapter 23 (the prison scene)
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: So, things are pretty good.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: How are yuo?

CupidsArrows: ...wow
CupidsArrows: My day was much less eventful
CupidsArrows: I finished an essay (it's due Wednesday but I like to be in time)
CupidsArrows: And then I had some time to play around in the workshop
CupidsArrows: I know a grad student who has the key, and she lets me try out new designs when I want to
CupidsArrows: (plus go nuts with the 3D-printer!)
CupidsArrows: :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sounds fun!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: So, you're in uni?

CupidsArrows: Yeah. Second year. You too?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: First year.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm just an innocent little freshman 😇

CupidsArrows: An innocent little freshman who's got into a fight with their professor two times today... ;-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Fine.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Not that innocent 😈

CupidsArrows: Haha
CupidsArrows: Reading your stories, I kinda figured

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Whaaaaaaat? *twirls hair*

CupidsArrows: Haha
CupidsArrows: I tried out some sketches if you wanna see...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: GIMMIE!

CupidsArrows: Haha
CupidsArrows: Sure! *file attached*
CupidsArrows: This is just a rough sketch
CupidsArrows: But I wanted to try some dresses
CupidsArrows: This is what I imagine the protagonist might wear in the beginning.
CupidsArrows: Do you think it could work?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: WOW!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: THIS IS AWESOME!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: yOU ARE SO TALANTED!

CupidsArrows: Haha, thanks.
CupidsArrows: It's just a first sketch. I'll try some other variations
CupidsArrows: But something like that might work as my first illustration.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: YOur... FIRST illustration?

CupidsArrows: You didn't think I'd only do one, do you? ;-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: That's all you have to do for the event...

CupidsArrows: I know
CupidsArrows: But I thought...
CupidsArrows: Perhaps you wouldn't mind if I did some more?
CupidsArrows: If I get inspiration?
CupidsArrows: And... the thing is - you give me a lot of inspiration.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I... I... I... wow!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: That's so...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Wow!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Of course I won't mind
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Make as many drawings as you want, haha
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I will love and cherish every single one.

CupidsArrows: Thaaaaaanks :-)
CupidsArrows: I will clean up the next one and send it to you in a little while.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: *file attached*
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: there's the first chapter
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: the first version anyway
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I might change it a bit
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I might change all of it
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: If it's trash
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Hopefully it's not trash
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Please tell me if it's trash
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Please don't hate me if it's trash

CupidsArrows: Thank you so much!
CupidsArrows: I know it's not trash
CupidsArrows: I know I will love it
CupidsArrows: I will read it right away.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Thank you!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Enjoy!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: (Hope you don't hate it)

CupidsArrows: I could never hate anything you have written :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Stooooooooooop

CupidsArrows: Haha
CupidsArrows: Talk to you later

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Talk to you later!

- - -

"So, how's your dork doing?"

"My *amazing artist* is doing very well, thank you very much."

Catra grinned at Glimmer from her usual spot in the armchair.

"My, my. Things turned out well, after all."

"They just red chapter ten and gave it plenty of praise."

"Told you!"

"Yeah, yeah," Glimmer distractedly said and eagerly thumbed her phone, which had just announced a new post. "Iiiiiiiih! New drawing!"

"They're spoiling you," Catra sniffed. "As if writer brats like you aren't entitled enough already."

"Like you haven't made like three different versions of the horse drawing for your writer," Glimmer shot back.

"Four," Catra muttered, her face heating up slightly. "And it's just because it's fun to try some new perspectives. I haven't drawn that many horses before so it's good practice."

"Aaaaand she sends you like ten heart emois for every new drawing," Glimmer teased.

Catra mumbled something ineligibly and busied herself with her stylus (she was working on a fifth version horse drawing). Glimmer smirked at her, took a deep breath and then opened the attachment she had just received.

It was breathtaking.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's breathtaking!

CupidsArrows: Glad you liked it. :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm so lucky I got you as an artist.

CupidsArrows: Haha. I'm the one who's lucky.
CupidsArrows: It's so much fun talking to you.
CupidsArrows: I can't believe I was so shy in the beginning

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You were shy?

CupidsArrows: Oh, so much!
CupidsArrows: You are so cool and confident and is such a star in the fandom
CupidsArrows: And I just do some doodles now and then.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's so much more than doodles! Yhou are amazing!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Like, super-duper amazing!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: ANd you always have something nice to say about everyone

CupidsArrows: That's because everyone is amazing :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Now you are jsut doing it for the bit :-)

CupidsArrows: A little, maybe :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Still, I can't believe you're illustrating one of my stories....

CupidsArrows: Um... actually... to tell the truth I might... already have... um done some art for some... one of your other stories.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😲😲😲😲😲

CupidsArrows: I never posted it because it felt a bit... creepy... since we never talked or anything...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Wow! Not creepy at all. Very uncreepy.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I mean... I'm flattered
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Which story did you illusttrate?

CupidsArrows: You know the ball room scene in the 'happily ever after' story? I... might have drawn the princess in that dress...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: NO WAY!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: CAN I SEE?

CupidsArrows: Sure :-) *sends attached file*

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😮 😮 😮 😮 😮

CupidsArrows: Do you... like it?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: IT'S THE BEST THING EVER!

CupidsArrows: You don't think it's creepy?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's thoughtful and considerate, you dolt!

CupidsArrows: Hehe, I guess...
CupidsArrows: I just don't want to come across as too forward...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You could never come across as too forward!

CupidsArrows: Really?
CupidsArrows: In that case...
CupidsArrows: I've really enjoyed chatting with you
CupidsArrows: And I love working together with you.
CupidsArrows: Would you like to video chat with me?

Glimmer slammed the lid of her desktop shut, white in her face. "CAAAAAAAAATRA!"

- - -

CupidsArrows: I'm sorry if it was too sudden, I shouldn't have suggested it.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: No, no.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I wast just surprised, is all.

CupidsArrows: We really don't have to video chat if you don't want to.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I want to!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I want to chat with you.

CupidsArrows: Great :-)
CupidsArrows: Now?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: ...
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sure!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'll just...
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Five minutes?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Haha

CupidsArrows: OK :-)

Bow took a deep breath and stretched his fingers. He quickly glanced around him to make sure the shelf behind him hadn't suddenly materialised something horribly embarrassing, debated whether or not his 'Princess Friendshipheart (tm)' Lego was horribly embarrassing, decided against it, and then took another breath.

He hoped it wasn't a bad idea to suggest a video chat with his favourite writer. They had a blast chatting with each other, and Bow thought there were some chemistry between them. He just hoped he wasn't wrong.

He sat up straight with a little 'eeep' as the incoming call signal interrupted his thoughts. He breathed in and out, put his best

smile in place and then pressed the answer button.

"Hi, so glad to finally see you in person..." Bow's voice trailed off as he stared at the hastily makeuped face of the most beautiful woman he had ever seen.

She stared back at him, large soulful, lavender eyes, quickly framed by just a touch too much mascara, and pink locks than Bow would give everything to run his fingers through.

The moment stretched. Neither said anything. Bow felt his heart beat. His lips were dry.

Then the woman screamed and the connection broke.

- - -

"CAAAAAAAAAATRA!"

"What? Is it a creep? Should I kill them?"

"What, no." Glimmer looked at her room mate in distress. "He's *hot*!"

Catra gave Glimmer - now in the seat of her rarely used 'mom' chair used for important video calls thanks to it's placement that allowed the background to be a white, neutral wall rather than the mess that was the rest of the room - a long, narrowed eye look.

"Is this a real problem or is it something stupid?"

"He's HOT!" Glimmer repeated. "How am I supposed to talk to him?"

"With your mouth?"

Glimmer gave her a panicky look. "Not helping!"

"What do you want me to say? Suggest other things you could use your mouth for?"

"NOT HELPING!"

Catra shook her head. "So your dork turned out to be hot. Big deal. Keep your cool, talk to him about fandom stuff just like you have done the rest of the week and you'll be good."

Glimmer stared at her for a few moments, but Catra calmly met her gaze in a manner that sugested that she would be of no furether help.

"But I cut the caaaaaall."

"Just tell him your laptop got knocked over by the roomba or something."

Glimmer gave her a disgruntled look, but before she could retort, the merry tune signalling an incoming call sounded.

"Hi," Bow said from the screen. "Sorry, the call was interrupted. If this is not a good time I can..."

"No!" Glimmer said with a huge, plastered on grin. "No problem at all, haha. My laptop was just knocked over by my cat." She looked offscreen with a stern expression. "My very NAUGHTY cat who will now SHUT UP!"

"Oh... OK." Bow gave her his friendliest smile. "Anyway, I'm really glad to see you in person. I'm such a fan."

"Oh! Wow! Um.... Which is your favourite character?"

"In the show or in your stories?"

"Either... Both... whichever you feel like!" Glimmer desperately gasped for air in a brave attempt not to pass out, which became harder as the artist puckered his lips in a simply adorable manner when he thought.

"I really like the protagonist. She is so brave, and she wants the best for everyone."

"She is great," Glimmer agreed. "And her relationship to her best friend/enemy/lover? Sooooo delicious."

"The princess is really pretty..." Bow said with a little blush.

"You draw her a lot," Glimmer teased, to her delight taking note that the artist was even cuter when he was flustered.

Glimmer suddenly felt the strong need to fluster the artist a lot.

- - -

"Aaaaaand done. What do you think?"

"It's very horsy."

"Of course it's very horsy. But is it a cool horse?"

Glimmer eyed the drawing critically.

"A bit dramatic, don't you think?"

"What, rearing on its hindlegs in front of a flaming sunset? What's so dramatic with that?"

"Everything?"

"Philistine!" Catra sniffed. "My target audience will love it."

"HorseGuuuurl, you mean."

"A target audience of one is still a target audience."

Catra waited for Glimmer to return her serve, but when she didn't she looked up to see her room mate lost in her tablet, which she was giving a look normally used for kittens in little woolly mittens.

"Don't tell me your dork sent you ANOTHER drawing?"

"He just want my opinion on the perspective."

"He wants you to pet him on the head and call him a good boy."

"It's not like that..." Glimmer mumbled, in a way that told Catra clear as can be that it was exactly like that.

"Wait!" she said with feigned surprise. "Do YOU want him to pat you on the head and call you a good boy?"

"Shut up."

"Are you dreaming of him being your good boy?"

"*Shut UP!*"

"I wonder what your *good boy* would do for a headpat if he was here right now..."

"Catra, I swear to God that if you don't shut up I will leave you in a cardboard box by the fire station."

Catra gave the flustered Glimmer a toothy grin and returned to her tablet. She reread the latest thread of messages she had got form her writer - a breathless tirade on how she built the mystery around the missing horse (it was painfully obvious it had been stolen by an evil princess, but Catra had way too fun pretending to be in suspense to let HorseGuuuurl know that she had figured it out pretty much immediately). Over by the desk, Glimmer giggled and all but jumped up and down in her chair as she traded compliments with the artist. Catra gave her a bemused look and opened up her drawing again. Perhaps the lighting wasn't exactly right...

"Whats for dinner?" Glimmer asked eventually, finally having been able to tear herself away from her tablet.

"How should I know," Catra countered.

"You haven't made dinner?"

"I made dinner yesterday."

Glimmer sniffed. "You brought a Tupperware full of leftover sandwiches from a conference reception."

"They left Kyle to guard the table," Catra happily said. "He's always been a pushover."

"So, you bullying Kyle counts as you getting dinner?" Glimmer demanded.

"You ate it, didn't you?" Catra shot back.

Glimmer thought it over.

It tracked.

"Fine, I'll get us food."

"I want pizza."

"We ate pizza three days ago."

"Yeah, so?"

"Fine. My treat."

"It better be, because I'm broke."

"Just shut up a moment..." Glimmer pushed some buttons on her pink phone, and then sat up straight with a radiant smile plastered on.

"Hi mom! How is my bestest mom? Oh? Wow. NO! She didn't? Oh, it's OK. I have an essay coming up next week so I'll have to spend the weekend by the computer... Yeah, poor Catra is sick... yeah, again." Catra rolled her eyes but didn't comment. "I just wish I had time to cook her a nourishing meal, but with my essay coming up, and with the exams looming closer... Oh would you mother! That's so thoughtful of you. Of course we will buy something healthy. Thank you mom. You are the best, mom. I love you, mom!"

Glimmer pressed the button to end the fall and held up a fist in the air. "Score. She's sending over money."

"You think she'll ever catch on?" Catra asked with bemused voice.

"Honestly, at this point I think she's just happy I'm eating anything at all," Glimmer shrugged. "Anyway, I fixed money so you get to order."

"You're really big on the whole 'not talking to strangers' lately, huh?"

"Shut up, brat cat."

- - -

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Hi!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Are you awake?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Or not in class?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Or... I don't know.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I have no idea what time zone you are in.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm awake
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: BUt I shouldn't be.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I should be sleeping
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I have class tomorrow
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: i hate my professor
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: WHo schedules class 8a m?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I think my professor might be a vampire.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: But I ate garlic pizza today, so I'm ready for him.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: But I can't sleep
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm working on my story
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And I hate it
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's trash
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: All of it
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You should talk to the organizers

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: They can pair you with someone else
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Who isn't a complete disaster
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Who dows'nm waste yhour talents
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: :-(

CupidsArrows: Whoa!
CupidsArrows: You're not a disaster!
CupidsArrows: I'm not going anywhere.
CupidsArrows: In the event, I mean.
CupidsArrows: I am in fact going somewhere, right now.
CupidsArrows: I'm on the night bus on my way home - I helped a friend with the audio for a gig.
CupidsArrows: But anyway, you're amazing
CupidsArrows: The best writer I know
CupidsArrows: Your story is really good.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😢😍?

CupidsArrows: I mean it!
CupidsArrows: You have real talent.
CupidsArrows: The emotions are raw and real and hits like a hammer.
CupidsArrows: But it's also really well paced.
CupidsArrows: What I have read so far is fantastic

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: You really mean that?

CupidsArrows: I really mean that.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😍😘

CupidsArrows: Please! Believe in yourself.
CupidsArrows: Because I really do.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: THat's really corny :-)
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: (also: Thanks)

CupidsArrows: I am VERY corny :-)
CupidsArrows: You should know that by now :-)

CupidsArrows: But that doesn't mean I don't mean it.
CupidsArrows: Because I do mean it.
CupidsArrows: You are amazing
CupidsArrows: And your story is amazing
CupidsArrows: You should feel amazing
CupidsArrows: I wish I could hug you until you feel how amazing you are.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Just hearing you say that makes me feel a lot better
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: *reading
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Wanna video chat?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Then I can hear you say it

CupidsArrows: I'd love to, really
CupidsArrows: But there's a bit of a drunken fight going on in the bus right now
CupidsArrows: So it might not be the best idea
CupidsArrows: Maybe we could video chat tomorrow?
CupidsArrows: I really like to video chat with you :-)
CupidsArrows: Then I can tell you all about how great you and your story is :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sounds good.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Probably for the best anyway.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: My negligee is a bit too risque for polite company ;-)
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Anyway, talk to you tomorrow *blows kiss*

CupidsArrows: ADSLKJFASDLKFLKAESFJ?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Can't hear you, I'm sleeping
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Zzzzzzzzz
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😇

CupidsArrows: ...

With beating heart Bow stared at the phone in his hand, until it became clear that his writing partner had said everything she intended on the subject.

- - -

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: OMG I'M SO SORRY!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I DIDN'T MEAN TO COME ACROSS AS A CREEP
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I WAS HALF SLEEPING WHEN I WROTE THAT
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: PLKEASE DON'T HATE ME

CupidsArrows: No worries :-)
CupidsArrows: It was fun
CupidsArrows: And a bit naughty ;-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm so glad you take it that way
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I didn't want to make you uncomfortable or anything.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Please tell me if I'm ever too much
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sometimes I'm too much
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I really want you to feel comfortable in our relationship
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: OUR OWKRING RELATIOMNSHIP!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: !!!!
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Haha
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Freudian slip
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I AM a bit naughty though 😊

CupidsArrows: Given some of your fanfics...
CupidsArrows: I could kinda tell... :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Oh shit,
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I had forgot you read those.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Um, what did you think of them?

CupidsArrows: Very hot ;-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Haha
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm kinda embarrassed now
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Please, don't look at me
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm shy
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: What did you think was hot with them?

CupidsArrows: The way the characters interact

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I bet 😜

CupidsArrows: NOT LIKE THAT!

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 🤣

CupidsArrows: I mean, how they interact on a personal level.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😘

CupidsArrows: NO, I MEAN...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: 😁

CupidsArrows: ...

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Want to try again?

CupidsArrows: If you're mean to me, I won't say anything more >:(

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: NOOOOOOOOO
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: PLEASE DON'T BE MAD
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I NEED YOUR COMMENTS ON MY FICS
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I NEED VALIDATION TO LIIIIIIIIIVE

CupidsArrows: Haha
CupidsArrows: Of course
CupidsArrows: I could never stay away anyway

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm counting on it...

CupidsArrows: Do you feel better today?
CupidsArrows: About your writing, I mean.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Much better.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Your pep talk yesterday really helped.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm so happy to have you.

CupidsArrows: And I'm so happy to have you :-)
CupidsArrows: It's so rewarding to see your story take shape.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Thaaaaaanks
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I started a new chapter this morning.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: It's about the escape from...
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: wait

CupidsArrows: OK
CupidsArrows: I'm waiting!

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sorry, my professor yelled at me abuot 'playing with my phone in class'
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Dang kdis of today with thei rnewfangled phones, mIright?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: He turned his back. Ha! I'll play wiht my phone as much as I

CupidsArrows: Are you OK?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Sorry, he turned to me again.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: But now he turned his back
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I'm a sneeeeeeaky phone ninja.

CupidsArrows: We could talk after class if you want to wait :-)

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Why would I want to do that?

CupidsArrows: So you don't get in trouble..?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: I won't get in trouble
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Ninja, remember?
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: alkjde

CupidsArrows: ??
CupidsArrows: You still there?

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Talk later
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Stupid prfessr

Bow put his phone away, and realised that he was still smiling. Despite being tired from the day before, the chat with PrincezzSparklezzzzz made him feel full of energy. He pondered his next drawing. Perhaps he could work in a prison scene...

His heart fluttered when the screen light up again, and he fumbled to open the message app.

PrincezzSparklezzzzz: BTW I'm Glimmer
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: That's my name
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: My real name
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Just wanted to tell you
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Cause I really think we're getting closer.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: And I lvoe chatting with you.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: So I wanted you to know my name.
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Hoep it's not too crossing a boundary
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Please tell me if I'm crossing a boundary
PrincezzSparklezzzzz: Because I don't want to make things awkward

Bow felt his inside heat up, in the best way possible.

CupidsArrows: I love talking to you too, Glimmer :-)
CupidsArrows: My name is Bow

- - -

"Hi, Glimmer!"

"Hi, Bow!"

Glimmer smiled at the artist on her screen.

"How is your day?"

"Better, now when I can talk to you."

"Oh!" Glimmer felt her cheeks getting warmer.

Bow smiled. "Talking to you always brightens my day."

Glimmer giggled and hid her face. "Stoooooooop."

"And today my day really needed brightening," he sighted.

"Oh no!" Glimmer gasped, struck with worry about her wonderful artist having to endure hardship. "What happened?"

"I had some problem with my drawing tablet," Bow sighed.

Glimmer looked suitably worried, which prompted him to explain. "There was a firmware error, so I had to install a new patch, but that made me lose the connection to the pen. I managed to reconnect it by reverting to an old version of the software, but then the sensitivity of the pen got worse. I thought I could compensate for that by changing the distance between the sensor and the tablet, but when I took the pen apart I realised that the lens was worn. So I decided I could just as well take the entire pen apart and rebuild it from the bottom up."

Glimmer blinked, trying to keep track of the rapid flow of words. "Wow. But now it works, right?"

Bow looked embarassed. "Well... when I took it apart I realised one of the connections were shoddy so I tried to redo it, but then a diode broke and when I tried to replace it, the entire chip got a crack. The brand of the tablet is obsolete, so I bought a broken

pen on ebay to salvage for parts. Only, it turns out that same chip was broken on that one."

"Oh no! So now you don't have a pen tablet?" Glimmer fingered the wallet in her pocket.

"Oh, we got it working," Bow said with a broad grin. "Turns out, the teaching assistant in the workshop class knows a guy who knows a guy who has access to that prototype chip workshop in town, and Entrapta - that's my TA - ran some tests on the chip and we could reverse engineer the basic structure. So she 'acquired' a new chip, and then she updated the photo sensor as well, and now my tablet run at the double performance. Only I have to use custom drivers and its absolutely not street legal."

"Wow!" Glimmer looked suitably impressed. "I'd just have bought a new tablet."

"I like to tinker," Bow said with a modesty that suggested that the word 'tinker' did a lot of heavy lifting. "And in order to try it out I made another drawing of the princess. Do you want to see it?"

Glimmer emitted sounds to the effect of her very much wanting to see it.

Over in her arm chair, Catra listened with narrow eyes. She put away the horse drawing she was working on, picked up her phone and opened the message tread for her roleplaying group.

```
Hey, 'trapta. Remember that pen tablet you hacked? Tell me
more about the dork you worked with...
```

- - -

Bow whistled as he finished up in the workshop. He worked as quickly as he could to make time for drawing before next class.

Mentally, he was already composing the scene he would draw. It would be from one of the later chapter, a rare soft breather before the plot caught up with the poor protagonists. The princess would

be sitting by the window. A soft smile playing on her lips, soft light sifting through her pink hair...

Bow closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

He saw the scene so vividly for his inner eye, but he couldn't deny that the person he imagined looked less like the princess from the show and more like the author he video chatted with almost every day now.

Bow was rapidly falling in love, with a person who for all he knew lived on the other side of the world. This might become a problem.

Still, it was with a spring in his steps he stepped out of the workshop, on his way to class, when he realised his path was blocked. A woman, slightly shorter than him, wearing a band t-shirt and a worn cat-ear headband (that somehow made her look more feral than cute) watched him critically with hands in her side.

"Um... excuse me?"

"Who's your favourite character?" she demanded.

He blinked. "Um... what?"

"In that princess show," she said impatiently and nodded at his bag. He followed her gaze to the key chain that depicted the main characters.

"Wha... um... my favourite is the main character? But I also love the moon princess. Are... are you a fan?"

She scoffed. "Don't change the subject. Are you some kind of horrible stalker?"

He blinked again. "*What?*"

"You heard me. What are the odds of the two of you living on the same campus? Are you playing her?"

Bow gave the woman a bewildered look. "Wha... Who are we talking about?"

Instead of answering she gave him a long, searching look. Bow, having no idea how to navigate the unexpected situation, simply stared back at her.

"You certainly look like a harmless dweeb," she said eventually. "And Entrapta vouches for you. OK, fine, you'll get a shot."

"Um... thank you?" Bow tried, and took a careful step forward as the woman moved to the side, leaving him a path. Then he made a frightened little yelp when she suddenly was directly in his face, canines showing.

"But if you hurt her, I'm feeding you to the pigs in the kiddie zoo. You got that?"

"I have no idea who you're talking about!"

The woman scoffed and took a merciful step back. "Go to the coffee shop by the duck pond after classes. Buy her a caramel latte with extra sprinkles."

"What? *Who!*?"

But the woman apparently felt she had said enough, and turned around to stroll down the path towards the library building, with Bow staring after her.

- - -

"Yes, Catra. I hear you Catra. Don't bite my head off."

Glimmer snarled at her phone as she walked past the pond. The ducks watched her in mild interest. "How can I be 'late'? What am I even here for?"

"Fine, I'm at the stupid coffee shop. Now what? HEY!"

Glimmer glared at her phone, suddenly silent after Catra hung up on her. She debated calling her room mate again, but if Catra had decided the conversation was over she'd probably not answer anyway.

She let out a huffy breath. and glanced around the room. It was only half filled, mostly by study groups or couples enjoying the cosy atmosphere. She wondered why Catra had been so insistent she was going her. Was she trying to set her up for something? Was this another ploy to get her into the roleplaying group with that purple haired grad student?

Glimmer pouted slightly as she walked up towards the counter. She could just as well get herself a coffee as she waited for the other shoe to drop. Perhaps Catra simply wanted her out of the apartment for some reason?

Her thoughts were interrupted by someone stepping up to her. Glimmer sighed and prepared her best dismissive sneer, which immediately turned into an open-mouth stare as she looked up into trusting, brown eyes, a friendly smile, hair she'd love to drag her fingers through.

"Hi Glimmer," Bow said and held up a caramel latte with extra sprinkles - just the way she liked them. "Can I buy you a coffee?"

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